The Gulf Buyer Response Benchmark

What happened to 144 anonymous buyer enquiries, and how to test your own agency

We sent 144 anonymous buyer enquiries to real estate brokerages across the GCC, most of them at night and at weekends, and recorded what happened next. This guide shows the aggregated results and gives you a simple way to measure your own agency against them.

How the test worked

01 We sent 144 anonymous buyer enquiries to brokerages across the GCC.

02 94 % of them arrived outside office hours, when real buyers often browse and ask.

03 87 enquiries went by email and 57 by WhatsApp.

04 All results are aggregated research. No brokerage, agent or person is named or described.

What buyers experienced

05 Out of all 144 enquiries, 63 % got no reply during our test.

06 Only 5 % were answered within 5 minutes.

07 Only 9 % were answered within one hour.

08 When brokerages did reply, the median first response took 9.4 hours.

09 For a buyer asking at night, that usually means an answer the next day, after they have contacted other agencies.

The channel gap

10 Via WhatsApp, 61 % of the 57 enquiries got a reply, with a median first response of 8.7 hours.

11 Via email, only 22 % of the 87 enquiries got a reply, with a median first response of 11.3 hours.

12 WhatsApp clearly gets more replies, but even there the typical answer arrived many hours later.

13 The lesson: the channel matters, but response time decides who gets the viewing.

Run the same test on your agency

14 Ask someone outside your team to send a buyer enquiry from an unknown number late on a weekday evening.

15 Send one through each channel you advertise: portal listing, website form, WhatsApp and email.

16 Repeat it on a weekend afternoon, when most offices are quiet.

17 Write down the exact time of the first reply for each enquiry, or note that none came.

18 Check whether the reply answered the question, asked about budget and timing, and offered a viewing slot.

19 Compare your times with the benchmark: 5 minutes, one hour and the 9.4 hour median.

What to fix first

20 Decide who owns night and weekend enquiries, by name, not by hope.

21 Set a first response target in minutes, not hours, and measure it every week.

22 Make WhatsApp your default reply channel, even when the enquiry arrives by email or portal.

23 Give every first reply three parts: a direct answer, one qualifying question and a concrete viewing time.

24 Repeat the test every month so you see the real buyer experience, not the one you assume.

Buyers do not wait for office hours, so the agency that answers first, with a clear next step, usually gets the viewing.

If your test shows a gap, book a 15 minute call and we will walk you through how agencies close it.

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